

Netflix Cinema Room

Watch movies together, in perfect sync, even when you are far apart.

Status	Target release	Owner
Ready for review	H1 2027	KEERTHISRI CINTHAM

1. The Problem

- Today, friends stream the same movie online while also on a video call. This eats up internet.
- Result: buffering, video that is 2-5 seconds out of sync, and echo from speakers.
- Anyone can press pause or skip at any time, which causes chaos.
- Rules differ by country, and kids can end up in adult movies.

2. The Idea

Download first, then watch together. Everyone downloads the movie (locked and encrypted) to their own device. During the movie, only tiny sync signals and the video call travel over the internet. So there is no buffering, and everyone sees the same frame at the same time.

3. Goals and How We Measure Them

Goal	Target
Everyone stays in sync	99% of the time, gap is under 0.15 seconds
No buffering during the movie	0 buffering events
People finish the movie	65% or more finish (movies over 90 min)
No echo problems	Fewer than 0.5% of sessions report echo
Free up storage after	80% or more of downloads deleted within 24 hours

4. Who Is It For

User	Who they are	What they want / what annoys them
Alex, the Host	Movie lover in a long-distance relationship	Wants top picture quality and control. Hates failed countdowns and a frozen partner screen.
Sam, the Guest	Casual viewer, invited partner	Wants to enjoy the movie, but sometimes needs a break. Feels bad interrupting.

5. How It Works

- **Check storage first:** need movie size + 500 MB free. Under 2 GB free means you cannot enter.
- **3 quality options:** Space Saver 720p (1.2-1.8 GB), Standard 1080p (3.5-5 GB, default), Ultra 4K (8-14 GB, needs 20 GB+ free).
- **Early start:** once the first 30 minutes are saved and the download is fast enough, the movie can begin.
- **Host is the clock:** the guest's player follows the host. Gap under 0.05 sec: do nothing. 0.05-0.5 sec: speed up or slow down very slightly (not noticeable). Over 0.5 sec: jump to the host's exact frame.
- **Video call:** direct link for 2 people, a helper server for 3-4 people.
- **Smart volume:** when someone talks, the movie gets quieter automatically.
- **Echo removal:** the movie sound is used to cancel itself out of microphones.

- **Weak internet:** if upload speed drops below 300 kbps, cameras turn into talking avatars.

6. The User Journey

Step	What happens
1. Join	Guest taps the invite link. We check account, country, profile type and plan. Download starts. Camera and mic are OFF by default. Tip shown: "Headphones recommended to avoid echo." Button: Enter Waiting Room.
2. Waiting room	Host sees who is ready. Option to turn on a 5-minute break. Button "Start Film for Everyone" unlocks when all are ready.
3. Watching	Movie keeps its full frame. Faces sit in the black bar below, so nothing blocks the picture. Each person picks their own subtitles. Emoji reactions float up the right edge. Host has Play, Pause and Scrubber. Guest has a "Raise Hand" button.
4. Raise Hand	Guest taps Raise Hand. Host sees "Sam requested a break" with [Pause Now] or [Ignore]. If paused, everyone's screen dims: "Paused by Host for Sam".
5. Intermission	For movies 100+ min, it pauses at the chapter nearest the halfway point. 5-minute countdown, soft chime at 30 seconds left. Host can resume early once everyone is ready.
6. After-show lounge	When credits start, the movie shrinks to a small corner box and faces get bigger. Both give star ratings that show together. Trivia and behind-the-scenes facts. Option to watch a related trailer or end.
7. Clean up	Pop-up: "Free up storage?" Choose Delete Now or Keep for 48 Hours. No answer means auto-delete after 48 hours.

7. Risks and How We Handle Them

Risk	Our fix
Movie not allowed in another country	Both accounts must be in the same country. Otherwise, show a clear error.
Camera or mic turns on by accident	Both are OFF by default. User turns them on.
Kids in adult rooms	Feature fully blocked on Kids Profiles. PIN needed for mature titles before download.
Piracy and expired licenses	License checked at start. If it expires mid-movie, pause and renew. Screen recording shows black frames.
Echo	Headphone tip plus echo cancellation using the movie sound.
Phone or laptop runs out of space	Storage check before download, plus a small 720p option.
Host misuses control or guest feels trapped	"Leave Party" button always visible. "Leave and Report" option sends the session for review.
Ads break the sync	Only ad-free plans, or the same ads play at the same time for everyone.

8. Not in Phase 1 (what we are NOT building yet)

Phase 1 is the first version. We keep it small on purpose. These things can come later:

- **Public rooms:** only invited people can join. No open rooms where strangers meet.
- **More than 4 people:** a room holds a maximum of 4.
- **Watching across countries:** both people must be in the same country, because movie rights differ by country.
- **Text chat on the screen:** typing would cover the movie. People can use voice, video and emojis instead.

9. Rollout Plan (how we release it, step by step)

We do not launch to everyone at once. We test in 3 stages:

Stage	Who uses it	What we check
1. Alpha	Only Netflix employees	Do downloads, syncing and echo removal work?
2. Closed Beta	10,000 pairs of real subscribers, US only	How well sync works, how fast the host reacts to Raise Hand, and whether storage clean-up works
3. Launch	Everyone, on iPhone, Android, Mac and Windows	Full release once the earlier stages go well